

authorised biography. He refused to read the book until it was published, giving French complete and unstinting access to all his papers in addition to candid interviews. Naipaul's non-interference makes him a great man, paradoxically bringing him closer to Gandhi's idea of what an artist should be.

The strength of French's book is precisely this wealth of material, both personal and professional, which was never available to anyone else before, not even in Naipaul's own autobiographical writings. Of the two parts of the book, the second, which deals with the later part of his life, is much more interesting and readable. What is revealing in the first part, though, is just how desperately Naipaul struggled in his early days in England, hating Oxford, failing his BLitt, encountering condescension, racism, humiliation and extreme privation before finally succeeding as a writer. Yet, what defines him and his writing is the unswerving devotion to the metropolis, his decision to leave Trinidad, the half-formed, post-colonial society in which he was born, and to find a place for himself in the universal civilisation dominated by Western modernity. It is only in London that his vocation is valued, which ensures for him all the privileges that come from pursuing it.

This book makes a very important contribution not just to Naipaul studies, but to our understanding of how a modern writer is made. In Naipaul's case, apart from the remarkable powers of observation and recall, the carefully honed, sharp-edged and precise literary style, it is an overweening prejudice and harshness of vision that fashioned the masterpieces that he wrote. Naipaul was unfair, opinionated, but always readable.

French has managed his enormously challenging task admirably. He is reticent and somewhat distant from his subject, never showing direct or overt approval or sympathy, but seldom withholding judgement. Much of the book is third person reportage, stylistically boring. Yet, this manages to convey enormous amounts of information. The book, however, suffers from a certain lack of juice, an exhaustion even, best illustrated by its very last word, "enough." The reader cannot share French's desire to move on. ■

TOP 10

BESTSELLERS

A monthly national list of bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG based on data from 15 retail outlets in six cities.

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (-)	A Prisoner of Birth	Jeffrey Archer	Pan Books
2. (1)	The Appeal	John Grisham	Random House
3. (2)	A Thousand Splendid Suns	Khaled Hosseini	Bloomsbury
4. (5)	The Japanese Wife	Kunal Basu	HarperCollins
5. (3)	The Kite Runner	Khaled Hosseini	Bloomsbury

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	The Secret	Rhonda Byrne	Atria
2. (-)	My Country, My Life	L.K. Advani	Rupa
3. (2)	We Are Like That Only: Understanding the Logic of Consumer India	Rama Bijapurkar	Penguin
4. (-)	The Monk Who Sold His Ferrari	Robin S. Sharma	Jaico
5. (-)	Rich Dad, Poor Dad	Robert T. Kiyosaki	Warner Business Books

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
6. (4)	Shantaram	Gregory David Roberts	Little Brown
7. (-)	Unaccustomed Earth	Jhumpa Lahiri	Random House
10. (-)	Five Point Someone: What Not To Do At IIT	Chetan Bhagat	Rupa
11. (8)	One Night @ the Call Centre	Chetan Bhagat	Rupa

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
6. (-)	The Last Mughal	William Dalrymple	Penguin
7. (14)	The Elephant, the Tiger and the Cellphone: Reflections on India in the 21st Century	Shashi Tharoor	Penguin
8. (18)	What The Customer Wants You To Know	Ram Charan	Penguin

Last month's rating in brackets

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Faqir Chand, Teksons, Full Circle; Mumbai: Crossword, Shah Book Stall, Danai Book Shop; Bangalore: Fountainhead, Gangarams; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Fountainhead